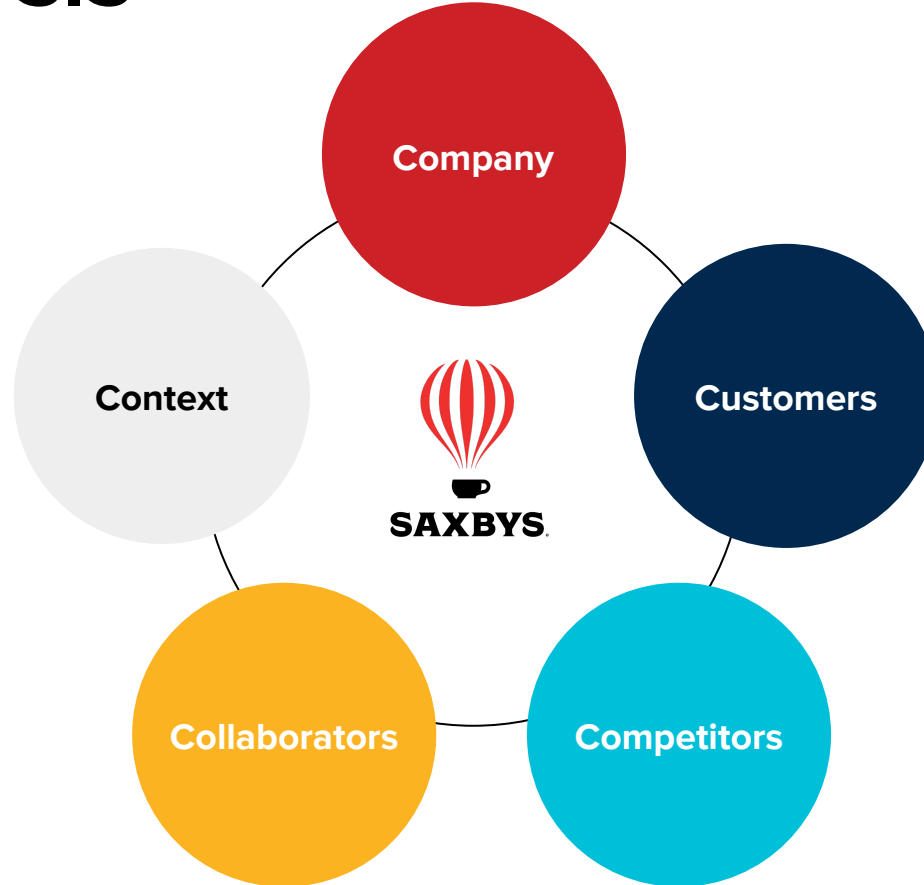




BRAND AUDIT

SAXBYS
BRAND AUDIT
02/06/2026

5Cs ANALYSIS



COMPANY – About Saxbys

Brand Overview

Saxbys is a **mission-driven hospitality brand**, which is described as an “**education company disguised as a coffee company**.” Built on the foundation of **experiential learning** and **student leadership**, its cafés serve **craft food and coffee** while **partnering with universities** that run **student-led locations** that develop **real-world business and leadership skills**. The brand positions itself as a **community-centered company** “**brewing real change**” by advocating for **education and opportunities** for the **next generation**.

Mission

“Make life better.” Saxbys focuses on improving lives through purpose-driven hospitality by using its cafés to build community and career-building opportunities for students through its E.L.P.

Vision

To brew real change in the communities it serves by advocating for education and opportunity, while empowering the next generation of leaders and entrepreneurs through experiential learning.

Values

- We are a Community, Serving Our Community
- Embrace being O.D.D. (Outgoing, Detail Oriented and Disciplined)
- Profit Creates Opportunity
- Live with Pride, Passion and Purpose
- Serve Yourself by Serving Others
- Care Personally and Communicate Openly

COMPANY – Offerings & Positioning

Product/Service Overview

- **Product 1 - Coffee & Beverage Menu:** Core café lineup of drip and espresso beverages plus a menu that keeps track of student demands with other tea/matcha options and its seasonal rotation drinks.
- **Product 2 - Food & Grab-and-Go:** Quick café foods designed for convenience. Portable breakfast and lunch items complement the beverage menu.
- **Service 1 - Digital Ordering & Rewards (App Ecosystem):** Features such as order-ahead, scan-to-pay, and points/rewards are built to increase consumer base and frequent visits.
- **Service 2 - Experiential Learning Platform (E.L.P) & Campus Partnerships:** Student led operations model where students lead, build soft skills, and the café becomes a real-world learning experience.

Brand Positioning

Saxbys is positioned as a **student-first café brand** built for campus life. It's fast, familiar, and community based, while giving students real leadership roles through its student-run café model.

Unique Selling Proposition (USP)

- **The café is the classroom (at a scale):** Saxbys' biggest advantage is its E.L.P, which turns cafés into student-run businesses led by student CEOs and leadership teams. Hence, Saxbys operates as a career-launching partner, and not a standard coffee vendor. The model is spanned across 26 locations on 21 campuses and has trained 150+ student CEOs, with many cafés staffed by ~45-60 student employees per location.
- **A coffee brand built around students and campus life:** Unlike chains that are built for the general public, Saxbys is designed around student routines and campus culture, which makes it feel like a “home base” for studying, meeting, and belonging. This boosts loyalty through relevance, not just their products.

COMPANY – Media Strategies

Medium/Channel	Strategy	Content Type	Interactions
 instagram	Saxbys uses Instagram as its main social channel, and uses it to promote new menu items, collaborate with other accounts, and build its community.	- Announcement for updates to the menu and new partnerships. - Collaboration with university official accounts and campus-based and local influencers. - Trend-jacking posts. - Stories of employees.	- Posts weekly, making it their most active social media channel. - Gets an average of 314.4 likes and 17.2 comments per post over the past 30 days, making it the most interactive platform. - Engagement is higher when posts feature collaborations with other universities or influencers. - Content is varied, giving audiences a well-rounded understanding of the brand.
 tiktok	Saxbys uses TikTok to keep up with current student fads while showcasing a more student-led side of the brand.	- Fad humor & visual content. - SCEOs/employees POV/interviews. - Drink-making videos. - More casual than the other platforms. - Set up challenges for drink tests.	- Posts mainly around community events or holidays, often sharing several related videos in the same week. - Content is designed to connect with Gen Z audiences. - Videos with trendy background sounds usually get more views. - Engagement is relatively low: across 27 posts in the past 6 months, posts average about 130 likes and 4.2 comments. The low comment count in particular suggests the content isn't effectively sparking conversation or prompting action.
 linkedin	Saxbys uses LinkedIn to communicate with professional and academic audiences and highlight its educational impact.	- Impact reports and hiring announcements. - Student leadership stories (SVPs and SCEOs), including highlights from Experiential Learning Platform (E.L.P) initiatives. - Updates on partnerships with universities.	- Posts only when there are new announcements. - Over the past 6 months (11 posts), the account averages 68 likes and 3.5 comments per post, mostly from people connected to the students featured. - Encourages interaction by inviting people to join the team, follow the brand's story, or engage with its impact. - Occasionally replies to comments and messages.

CONSUMERS - Target Audience

Primary Audience - College Students

Demographic

- Age: 18–24 years
- Highly diverse population.
- Income level: Limited disposable income. Primarily dependent on parental support.

Geographic

- On-campus or nearby off-campus housing.
- Lives in urban or suburban areas.
- Concentrated in the Mid-Atlantic—especially Pennsylvania—and nearby states.

Purchase Behavioral

- Coffee and food purchases are often tied to school schedules.
- **Price sensitivity is high, but students are willing to spend regularly on small, affordable indulgences that feel rewarding.**
- **Strong reliance on mobile ordering**, digital payments, and loyalty programs to save time and maximize value.
- Seasonal items, limited-time offers, and student-specific deals encourage trial and repeat visits.
- Decisions are driven by convenience, especially between classes or during high-stress academic periods.

Media Consumption

- Highly active on Instagram and TikTok, favoring short-form, visually engaging, and trend-driven content.
- Engage with content that feels authentic, shareable, and **relevant**, including influencer and peer-led posts.
- Use university platforms (email, student portals, campus event listings) as **trusted sources** for information and opportunities.
- Moderate use of LinkedIn, mainly for internships, career exploration, and professional development.

Psychographic

- **Mood-driven ordering:** Students choose comfort drinks during stress and trend-driven options in social or relaxed moments.
- **Peer-influenced choices:** Friends' orders and social media visibility subtly shape what students choose.
- **Low-pressure socializing:** Interactions are casual and brief, like quick check-ins with friends.
- **Ease over effort:** Fast-paced lives make low-stress, effortless experiences more appealing.
- **Emotionally buffered:** Cafés offer a calm middle ground, less chaotic than dorms, less rigid than libraries.
- **Late-day relevance:** Cafés that accommodate afternoon or evening needs (less sweet, lower caffeine) fit student schedules better.
- **Quietly ambitious:** They care about future outcomes even when present motivation dips.

COMPETITORS

Brand	Positioning	USP	Strength	Weakness	Social Engagement
	Mission-driven hospitality brand that positions itself as an educational, purpose-driven company disguised as a coffee company.	Uses an Experiential Learning Platform (E.L.P) with student-led cafés that build leadership experience.	- Operational model (E.L.P) is a standout - Campus/community relevance - Mission-led narrative	- Smaller footprint & limited reach - Consistency in student worker experience varies - Narrower audiences outside campuses	Instagram regularly updated with large following; TikTok not utilized much; Facebook used for updates and promotions; Limited presence on YouTube
	Mass premium coffeehouse brand centered on community and the coffeehouse experience.	Premium, personalized coffee along with being a space for people between work and home, aka "the third place" experience.	- Massive distribution - Frequent visits with loyalty and app - Seasonal launches drives spike in consumers	- Prices are higher - Feels less local and authentic - Labor controversies	Strong engagement around around drops/promos on TikTok, IG, Facebook. YouTube is not a core platform.
	Value and convenience brand built around speed and everyday energy.	Fast, frequent routine fueled by promotions that keep brand culturally relevant.	- Strong value perception - Habit and convenience for many - Promos drive buzz	- Less premium - Transactional experience - Menu lacks in options	Usage of trends and collabs driving high engagement on IG and TikTok. Facebook has light engagement, YT not used much.
	Speciality coffee brand that focuses on quality and craft, with a premium feel.	Known for product innovation (draft latte/RTD) that bring café-style drinks into ready-to-drink formats.	- Strong quality reputation - Clear "signature" product - Premium branding	- Fewer locations than chains - Higher prices = less visits - Less connected to campuses	IG has large following and strong presence/visuals. Lighter engagement and consistency on FB and TikTok. Occasional videos on YT.

COLLABORATORS

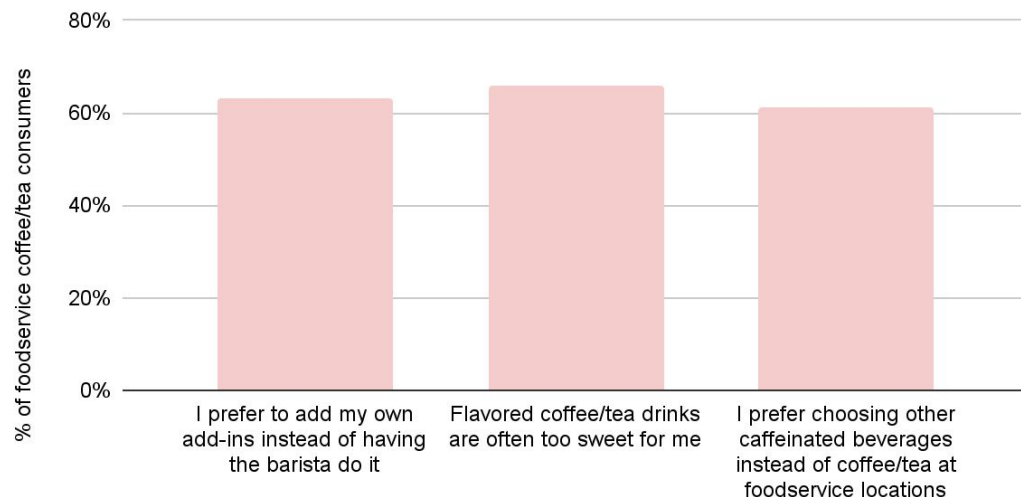
Brand	Contribution	Strengths	Opportunities
Josue Morales' Coffee Mill	As one of various coffee origin farmers, they provides Saxbys with small-batch, traceable coffee, custom roasts, and support in Saxbys' barista training, quality control, and origin storytelling.	Feels authentic and long-term, not transactional. Aligns with values around fairness, transparency, and global impact.	Make the relationship more visible to customers through origin callouts, short videos, and student-facing education tied to the experiential learning model.
 Big Brothers Big Sisters OF AMERICA	Strengthens Saxbys' people-first mission by aligning the brand with mentorship, guidance, and personal growth.	Highly trusted and widely recognized nonprofit; reinforces credibility.	Activate the partnership more in-store and on campus through volunteer programs, seasonal campaigns, and storytelling around mentorship and leadership.
 Jevs Human Services	Directly supports workforce development and job readiness, reinforcing Saxbys' "earn while you learn" positioning.	Strong operational fit with Saxbys' focus on early-career talent and upward mobility.	Build clearer talent pipelines, co-brand training or certifications, and share impact metrics to show how the partnership creates real economic opportunity.
 CALIFIA FARMS®	Supplies plant-based milks used across Saxbys' espresso and specialty drinks, helping meet strong student demand for dairy alternatives and supporting a more inclusive menu.	Well-known, design-forward brand; aligns with sustainability-forward perceptions.	Co-branded sustainability messaging in-store and on social, and use menu defaults or incentives to increase plant-based adoption.

CONTEXT – Market Trends

Beverage & Coffee Category (U.S.)

- **Coffee is massive and still growing:** the U.S. coffee market generate ~\$90B in 2025, and roasted coffee is the biggest revenue driver (~\$70B). ([Statista](#))
- **Speciality coffee is mainstream:** 46% of U.S. adults had specialty coffee in the past day, surpassing traditional coffee (42%). This supports espresso-led menus and seasonal LTO purchases. ([National Coffee Association, 2025](#))
- **Sugar is a turnoff, not a treat:** 66% of Gen Z say flavored coffee/tea is too sweet. 60% of juice consumers would drink more if sugar weren't a concern. ([Mintel, 2025](#)) ([Mintel, 2025](#))
- **Caffeine matters more than coffee:** 61% of Gen Z and 57% of Millennials choose non-coffee/tea caffeinated drinks at foodservice. Younger consumers are caffeine-driven, creating room for matcha, refreshers, and functional energy. ([Mintel, 2025](#))

US: foodservice coffee/tea attitudes, atmosphere and experience - NET - any agree, by GenZ, 2025

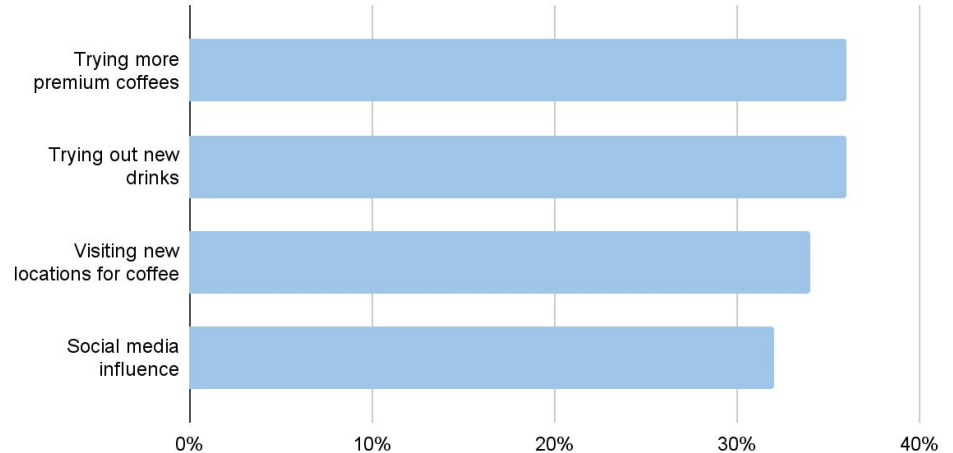


CONTEXT – Market Trends

Campus & Student Market

- **Students are buying off-campus more:** 60% of student food and beverage purchases are off-campus, and 36% come from grocery/convenience stores. ([Technomic, 2025](#))
- **Mobile/digital ordering is expected:** loyalty/app ecosystems are used more. Starbucks reported 35.5M 90-day active Rewards members (Q1 FY26), showing how much repeat behavior is tied to apps and rewards. ([Starbucks Investor Relations, 2026](#))
- **Gen Z is more likely to increase outside coffee purchases,** driven primarily by trying new or premium drinks (36%) and visiting new locations (34%). Growth is fueled by **freshness and experience**, even amid higher prices. ([Mintel, 2025](#))

US: top four reasons for buying more coffee drinks at foodservice locations in 2025



CONTEXT – Cultural Shifts

Plant-based alternatives become a cultural default

- Nearly 47% of Gen Z consumers choose non-dairy milk when drinking coffee, **often for taste, digestion, or habit rather than activism**, making plant-based options a normalized choice. ([Kerry North America](#))

Short-form videos are Gen-Z's “search engines.”

- Teenagers use YouTube (~70%) and TikTok daily (57%) (Facebook has much lower usage.) ([Pew Research Center](#))
- Discovery happens through content creators, trends, and “try this drink” content. This means that brands need more platform-based storytelling.

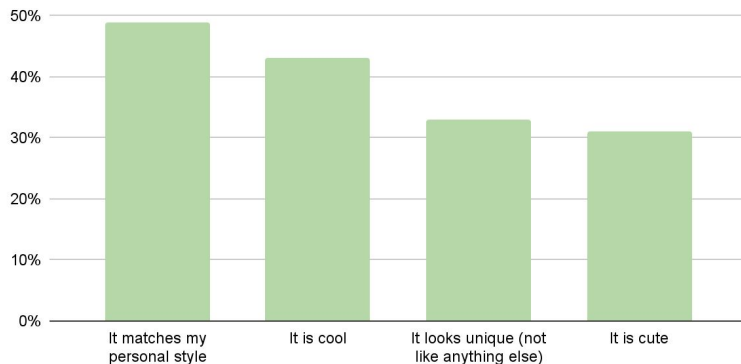
Blurring productivity and leisure

- Younger consumers are rapidly reshaping coffee habits, about 19% of U.S. consumers drink iced coffee at least once a day, and for many it's seen as a **“me-time” or lifestyle beverage** rather than solely a morning fuel, reflecting a blending of work/study with leisure occasions. ([Innova Market Insights](#))

Self-Expression Over Status

- Gen Z values individuality and self-expression over traditional status symbols, 69% agree that brands “try too hard to look cool,” preferring affordable “dudes” and products that reflect personal style rather than luxury or trend-driven status. ([Mintel](#))

US: Gen Z teens - most important aspect of appearance of purchases (select up to three), 2025



CONTEXT – SWOT

Strengths

- Saxbys' E.L.P. model creates student-led cafés with real leadership roles (Student CEO), which most coffee chains don't offer.
- **Saxbys has a measurable campus footprint:** 26 locations across 21 campuses, giving built-in access to students and daily demand.
- Saxbys' B-Corp / purpose-led identity strengthens credibility with students who prefer value-driven brands.

Weaknesses

- Saxbys has lower awareness than major chains, so many students default to bigger names.
- Relying on the student rush during the semesters makes demand less consistent during breaks and summers.
- As a smaller brand, Saxbys has less promo/marketing scale, limiting its reach compared to national competitors.

Opportunities

- **Peer-led discovery is on the rise:** students trust student creators and campus voices more than polished brand ads.
- **Demand for “third spaces” is growing:** students want places to study and socialize beyond the morning coffee run.
- **Purpose-driven spending is increasing:** students respond to brands that show clear and specific impact, not vague mission statements.

Threats

- **Big chains can win on both convenience and experience.** Starbucks/Dunkin' can outspend on promos, run seasonal drops, and still maintain study-friendly spaces near campuses.
- **Cost pressure hits smaller brands faster.** Labor, rent, and ingredient increases can result in higher prices or staffing changes that affect consistency and value perception.
- **Campus surges can affect operations.** Orientation, finals, and major events can create long lines and slower service, which quickly breaks routine behavior and lowers convenience.

5Cs SUMMARY / TAKEAWAY

Company

Saxbys is a mission-driven, student-first coffee brand that blends hospitality with experiential learning through its student-led café model.

Consumers

College students live fast-paced, campus-centered lives, value convenience and comfort, and rely on affordable treats as small daily rewards despite limited disposable income.

Competitors

Saxbys competes with large chains that win on scale and promotions and specialty cafés that win on craft and quality. Its education-centered, campus-integrated model is unique but challenged by lower awareness and smaller reach.

Collaborators

Saxbys' partners support ethical sourcing, social impact, workforce development, and plant-based inclusion, reinforcing the brand's people-first and values-driven positioning.

Context/Climate

Coffee consumption is routine, but choice is increasingly driven by experience, speed, and digital ecosystems. Gen Z discovery happens through short-form content, creating white space for authentic, student-led storytelling.

STRATEGIC JUMPING-OFF POINTS

Human Insights

- **“Coffee is mood booster, not a brand choice.”** College students don’t wake up comparing Starbucks and Saxbys. They choose what fits the moment: “I’m late,” “I’m stressed,” “I need to lock in,” “I want a treat,” “I want to be around people.” The brand that wins isn’t always the one with the best coffee; it’s the one reliably matches the student’s state of mind with right mix of speed, comfort, and vibes.
- **“Belonging is built through small signals.”** For Gen-Z, community feels real when it shows up in tiny, repeatable moments like being recognized, feeling safe to take up space, and seeing people like you in the room. They feel this way because they’re navigating constant social comparison and a lack of trust in institutions, so they rely on environments that offer low-pressure social connection and mental safety instead of big and performative “community” messaging. Third places like cafés matter because they eliminate isolation and help students feel anchored to a routine and identity outside of class.
- **“Gen-Z rewards proof, not promises.”** Students like purpose, but they’re skeptical when it sounds like fake marketing. They trust impact when it’s specific and verifiable (real student outcomes, stories and receipts) and when supporting it doesn’t require extra effort. This matches the broader Gen-Z expectations of wanting brands to understand real everyday challenges and act genuinely.
- **“Student-run institutions feel more authentic because it’s closer to them.”** Saxbys being student run matters because it changes the power dynamic. Instead of a corporate brand “selling” to students, it can feel like students are building something for other students. The peer closeness can increase trust (“this place understands campus life”), pride, and participation with students being more likely to bring friends, share or show up for events when students are the face of it. This also fits how Gen-Z discovers choices through creators, comments and student-led content rather than polished brand ads.